the Supreme Court. Now, SCs will have 20 per cent (from 16 per cent earlier), STs 2 per cent (from 1 per cent), EBCs 25 per cent (from 18 per cent) and BCs 18 per cent (from 12 per cent) quota in the state. The earlier quota of 3 per cent for EBC women has been done away with. Along with the 10 per cent quota for the economically weaker sections (EWS), Bihar will now have 75 per cent reservations.

Alongside, Nitish also disclosed the socio-economic findings of the survey, which gave an insight into the extent of poverty in Bihar. Some 34 per cent of the state's 9.4 million households were classified as poor, with a monthly income under Rs 6,000. Though many enumerators privately conceded that several respondents are likely to have under-reported their income for a variety of reasons, including the anticipation of government assistance, there is no denying that poverty cuts across caste groups. It was found to be the highest among the SCs at 43 per cent, followed by the EBCs (36 per cent) and BCs (33 per cent). Based on these findings, the government announced a one-time financial assistance of Rs 2 lakh to each such family and an additional Rs 1 lakh to 63,840 homeless families, mostly from the Dalit communities, to build houses. The cost of this collective largesse to the state exchequer? Rs 2.5 lakh crore over the next five years.

Once announced, the two quota bills met with little resistance. Governor Arlekar, though a BJP man, gave his approval in a matter of 10 days. For, closer to the general election, the saffron party can ill-afford to alienate the OBC vote bank. And Bihar sends 40 MPs to the Lok Sabha. The 65 per cent reservations could still run into a legal hurdle, having breached the Supreme Court-set limit of 50 per cent. However, in the event of a legal challenge, the state government does have the recourse of approaching the Centre to place the legislation in the Ninth Schedule of the Constitution. The said provision contains a list of central and state laws that cannot be challenged in the courts.

THE NITISH GAMEPLAN

What does Nitish hope to achieve with his caste survey gambit? Reclaim his position in the state, for one, as also in the national imagination. Having built unqualified political equity for himself since he took charge as chief minister in 2005, and carving a formidable vote bank of EBCs, Nitish frittered a lot of the goodwill away with his mercurial actions of the past six years. The fantastic victory of the 2015 assembly election in the face of the massive Modi wave just the year before, soured when he chose to leave the *mahagathbandhan* and join the NDA in July 2017. It may have fetched a great run for his party in the 2019 Lok Sabha election, when the JD(U) won 16 of Bihar's 40 Lok Sabha seats, a gain of 14 over the previous election. But Nitish paid the price in the assembly election the year after when he became chief minister again only because of the BJP's generosity since his own party's tally had dropped to 43—its worst showing ever in the state, slipping to third place behind the RJD and BJP.

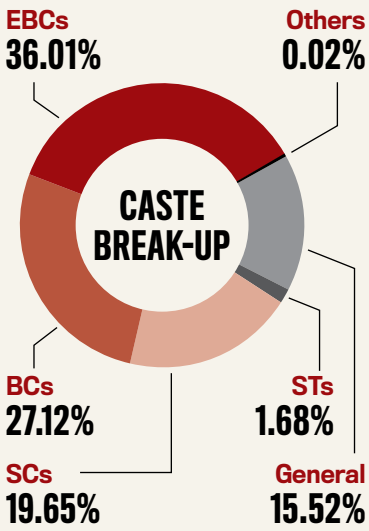
And the BJP has never lost momentum since, chipping away at Nitish's vote base, in the hope of winning future elections on its own. From showcasing Prime Minister Narendra Modi's own backward caste credentials to picking Kushwaha leader Samrat Choudhary as state president in March this year and roping in Upendra Kushwaha as a new alliance partner, the saffron party is systematically building a base in the Hindi heartland state. And while Nitish has been relentless in lavishing schemes on EBC, OBC and SC populations, by enhancing reservations, he hopes to turn the direction of the political winds

CASTE AND OTHER COUNTS

On November 9, Nitish made the findings of his caste-based survey public, and enhanced reservations by 15 per cent while announcing financial incentives for the poor and the homeless in Bihar

TOTAL POPULATION
130,725,310

NO. OF CASTES
215



WITH HIS CASTE COUNT, QUOTAS AND DOLES, NITISH HOPES TO COUNTER THE **HINDUTVA, OBC, NATIONALIST AND WELFARIST POLITICS** OF THE BJP